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General Knowledge
Modern History

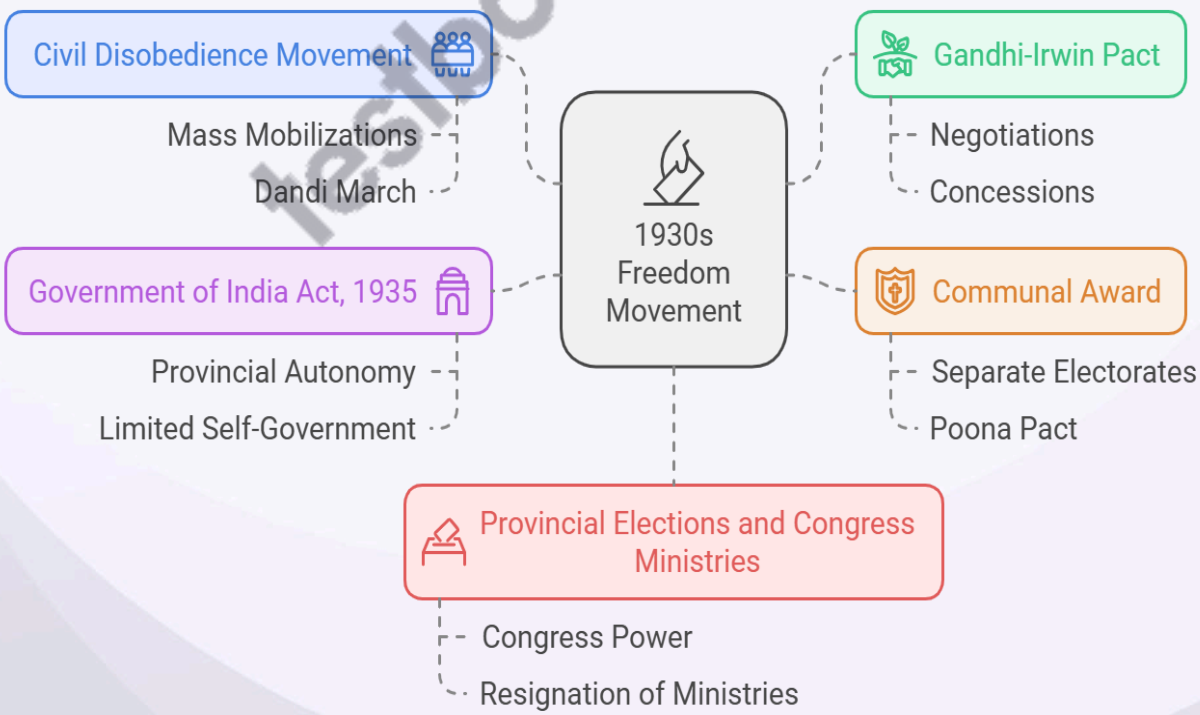
STUDY NOTES

Freedom Movement
(1930-1939)

Freedom Movement (1930 - 1939)

Introduction

- The **1930s** were a pivotal decade in India's struggle for independence, characterized by intensifying efforts against British rule through mass movements, political negotiations, and legislative reforms.
- The period began with the **Civil Disobedience Movement, sparked by the iconic Dandi March led by Mahatma Gandhi**, which mobilized millions in defiance of British laws.
- This decade also saw significant negotiations in the form of the **Round Table Conferences**, albeit with limited success.
- Landmark agreements such as the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact and the Poona Pact** shaped the political landscape, as did the Communal Award, which stirred debates on communal representation.
- The enactment of the **Government of India Act, of 1935**, although falling short of Indian aspirations, laid the groundwork for self-governance in provinces.
- The 1930s culminated with Congress forming provincial ministries, which later resigned en masse in 1939 to protest India's involvement in WWII.
- This marked a decisive stand against colonial policies.
- This phase of the freedom movement solidified national unity and advanced the Indian demand for complete independence.



Key Events from 1930-1939:

Event/Topic	Date	Details/Key Points
Civil Disobedience Movement	**1930**	It was **launched by Gandhiji** after the **Lahore Session (1929)** demand for Purna Swaraj. Major activities: Dandi March, refusal to pay taxes, salt satyagrahas, and non-cooperation activities across India.
Dandi March	**March 12 - April 6, 1930**	Gandhi's 240-mile march to Dandi to **protest the salt tax** initiated the CDM.
Gandhi-Irwin Pact	**March 1931**	Agreement between Gandhi and Irwin: ended the first phase of CDM, released political prisoners and allowed salt production. Gandhi agreed to suspend CDM and attend the Second RTC.
Round Table Conferences	**1930-1932**	- **1st RTC (1930)**: Congress boycotted; limited outcome. - **2nd RTC (1931):** Gandhi attended, but no consensus was reached. - **3rd RTC (1932):** Minimal participation from Indian leaders, no substantial results.
Communal Award	**August 16, 1932**	British PM Ramsay MacDonald's proposal for separate electorates for **Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Anglo-Indians, depressed classes, etc.** It was rejected by Gandhi, leading to his fast unto death.
Poona Pact	**September 24, 1932**	Agreement between **Gandhi and Ambedkar.** Separate electorates for depressed classes were replaced by reserved seats.
Government of India Act, 1935	**1935**	Introduced provincial autonomy, and federal structure, but retained British control in central governance. Congress opposed but contested elections under the Act in 1937.
Provincial Elections	**1937**	Congress won a majority in most provinces and formed ministries in **Bombay, Madras, Central Provinces, Orissa, United Provinces, and later in NWFP and Assam.**
Congress Rule Initiatives	**1937-1939**	Social and civil reforms: prohibition, welfare programs for Harijans, educational and health improvements, lifted press restrictions, released political prisoners, and promoted indigenous industries.

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Resignation of Congress Ministries	**October 1939**	Congress ministries resigned to protest against the Viceroy's unilateral decision to involve India in WWII without consulting Indian leaders.
Forward Bloc	1939	Founded by **Subhash Chandra Bose** after he resigned from the Indian National Congress. Bose established the Forward Bloc as a faction within Congress to rally support for a more radical approach to achieving independence. Bose aimed to gather all left-wing sections of the Congress and encouraged more aggressive resistance against British rule. The Forward Bloc advocated for complete independence and sought support from international allies, including Axis powers during WWII.

- ## Civil Disobedience Movement (CDM) and Dandi March (1930):

Background and Cause:

- Growing dissatisfaction with British policies led to the demand for Purna Swaraj (complete independence) at the **Lahore Session of INC in 1929,** chaired by Jawaharlal Nehru.
- Gandhi's 11 demands included a reduction in army expenses, abolition of the salt tax, reduction in land revenue, and release of political prisoners.

Dandi March (March 12 - April 6, 1930):

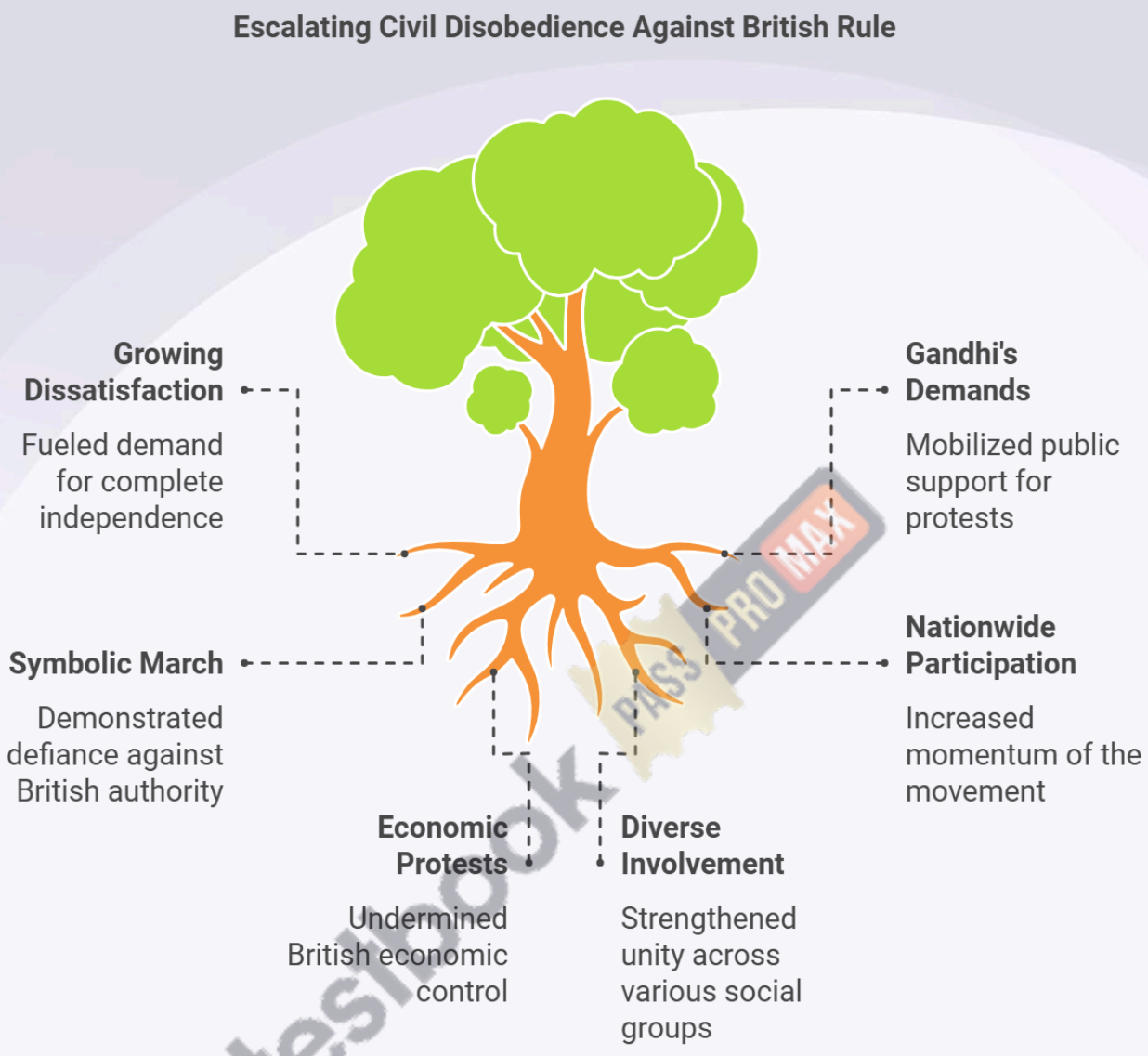
- Gandhi's symbolic 240-mile march from **Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi** marked the beginning of the CDM. By breaking the salt law, Gandhi openly defied British authority.
- It Inspired a nationwide civil disobedience movement, with participation from students, women, farmers, and workers.

Expansion of CDM:

- Salt Satyagraha in regions like **Orissa, Tamil Nadu, and the United Provinces.**
- **No-rent and no-revenue campaigns** emerged, urging people to refuse taxes and boycott British institutions and goods.

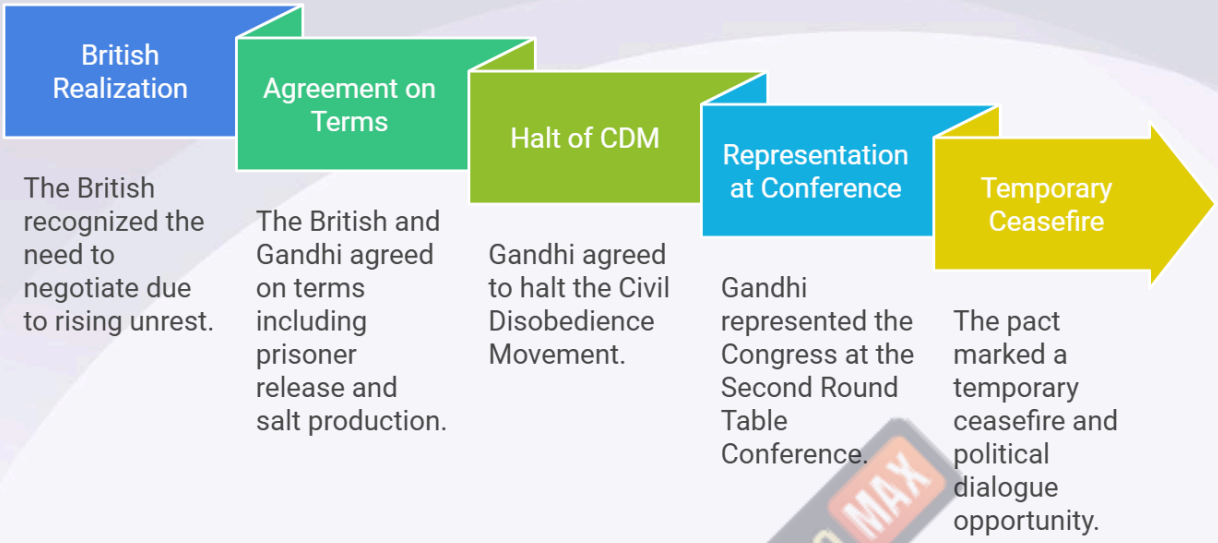
Participation:

- **Women**: Engaged in picketing shops selling foreign goods.
- **Students and Youth:** Boycotted foreign cloth and promoted Indian products.
- **Peasants**: Stopped paying land revenue, a significant form of economic protest against the British.



- **Gandhi-Irwin Pact (March 1931)**
  - The British realized the need to address India's rising unrest and negotiate with Gandhi.
  - British agreed to release political prisoners, return confiscated properties, and allow salt production in coastal areas.
  - In return, Gandhi agreed to halt the CDM and represent Congress at the Second Round Table Conference.
  - This pact marked a temporary ceasefire and provided an opportunity for political dialogue with the British.

Gandhi-Irwin Pact Sequence



- ## Round Table Conferences (1930-1932)

First Round Table Conference (1930):

- It was held in London. Congress did not participate due to the ongoing CDM, but other Indian leaders and princely states attended.
- It was largely unproductive due to Congress's absence.

Second Round Table Conference (1931):

- Gandhi represented Congress but faced obstacles from the Muslim League and princely states, which demanded separate representation.
- No consensus was reached, and Gandhi returned disappointed.

Third Round Table Conference (1932):

- Congress again boycotted; attended by minor representatives.
- It produced limited results, as Indian leadership was largely absent.

- ## Communal Award and Poona Pact (1932)

Communal Award by British Prime Minister **Ramsay MacDonald** (August 1932):

- Separate electorates for various communities were introduced, including the depressed classes.
- **Gandhi's Reaction:** Opposed the award, as he viewed it as divisive; began a fast unto death in protest.

Poona Pact (September 24, 1932):

- **Negotiated by B.R. Ambedkar and Gandhiji**, abandoning separate electorates for reserved seats for the depressed classes in provincial legislatures.
- **Significance**: Averted potential communal divisions while ensuring representation for the depressed classes.

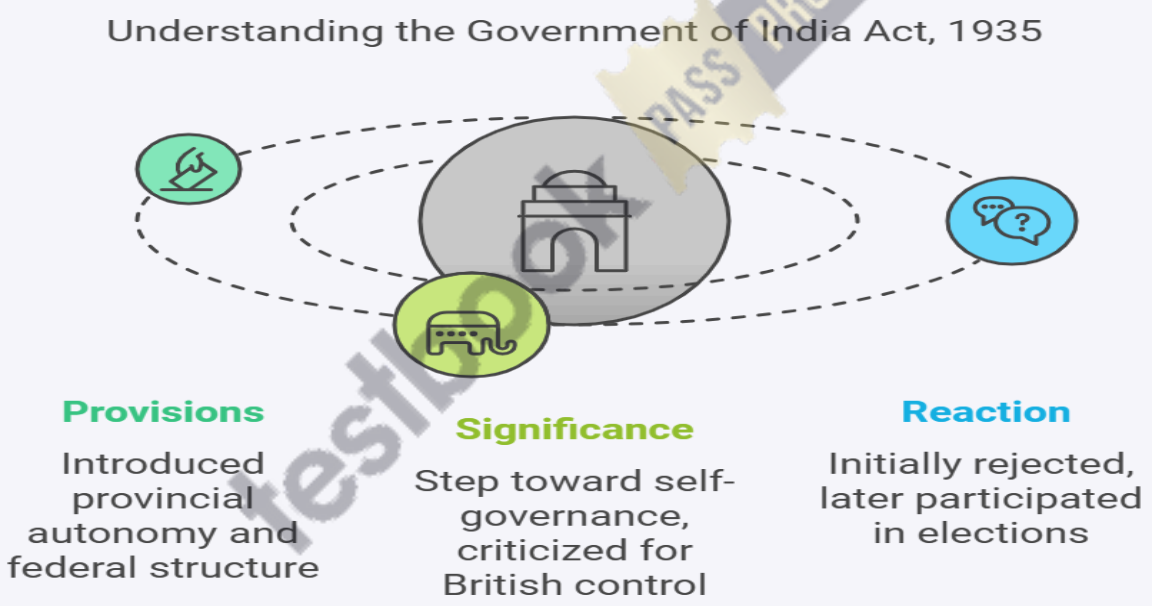
Government of India Act, 1935

Provisions:

- Introduced provincial autonomy and established a federal structure, although central powers remained with the British.
- Significance: Marked a step toward self-governance, though heavily criticized for maintaining British control over key areas like defense and foreign policy.

Reaction:

- Congress and other nationalist leaders rejected the Act but later decided to participate in provincial elections under the Act to gain political influence.



Provincial Elections and Congress Ministries (1937)

Provincial Elections:

- Held under the **Government of India Act, of 1935.** Congress contested elections and won majorities in multiple provinces.
- **Formation of Ministries:** Congress formed governments in provinces like Bombay, Madras, and the United Provinces.

Congress Rule Initiatives (1937-1939):

Social Reforms:

- Promotion of khadi, **prohibition of liquor** in certain areas, and welfare initiatives for Harijans (Dalits).

Educational and Economic Reforms:

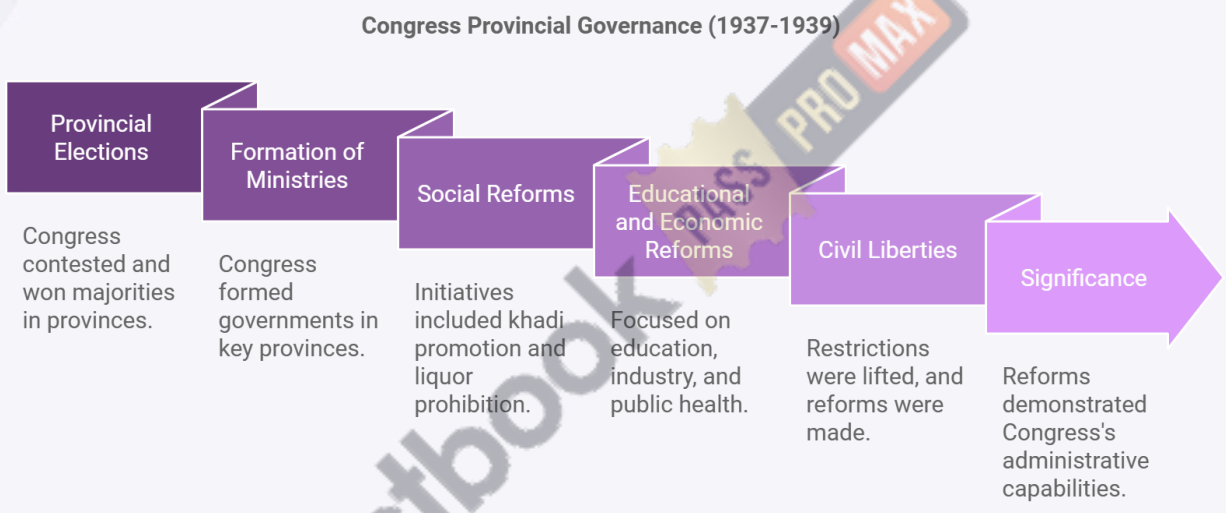
- Improved primary and technical education, promoted indigenous industries, and encouraged public health and sanitation.

Civil Liberties:

- **Lifted press restrictions**, released political prisoners, restored arms licenses, and reformed police practices.

Significance:

- Enabled Congress to implement reforms and demonstrate their administrative capabilities. It increased public confidence in Indian leaders' ability to govern.



Resignation of Congress Ministries (1939)

- Background: The British declared India a participant in WWII without consulting Indian leaders.

Congress Reaction:

- In protest against this unilateral decision, Congress ministries resigned, effectively ending the collaboration with British authorities.
- This decision marked a shift back to confrontation with the British and set the stage for future mass movements.

Forward Bloc

- **The Forward Bloc was established in 1939 by Subhash Chandra Bose** after he resigned from the Indian National Congress due to ideological differences with the Congress leadership, particularly with Gandhi's approach to non-violent struggle.

- The primary aim of the Forward Bloc was **to unite all left-wing and radical sections of Congress** and mobilize the masses for a more assertive, militant approach toward achieving complete independence from British rule.
- The Forward Bloc advocated for a socialist and radical stance, promoting a strong nationalist sentiment and encouraging immediate action against British rule, contrasting the moderate and non-violent stance of Congress at the time.

International Alliances:

- During World War II, Bose and the Forward Bloc sought alliances with international powers opposed to British imperialism, including the Axis powers, to support India's freedom struggle.

Legacy:

- The Forward Bloc became a symbol of impatience and frustration among Indians who were dissatisfied with the Congress's pace and approach.
- It reinforced the demand for immediate and uncompromising independence, inspiring a more assertive faction within India's independence movement.
- **The Forward Bloc** reflected a shift towards a more radical approach within the freedom struggle, highlighting the diversity of strategies and ideologies among Indian leaders in the final push for independence.